

INTERNAL HARD DRIVES

Serial ATA (up to 250 GB)

Samsung SP2504C

Specifications

250 GB SATA 2 (300 MBps); 8 MB I/O buffer

Our Verdict

Our benchmarks showed Samsung's SP2504C to be consistently ahead in a majority of (if not all) the benchmarks we threw its way. This is a two-platter drive with an areal density of 125 GB per platter. We've seen other drives with similar capacities sporting three platters. This is one of the reasons for the improved performance—fewer mechanical parts is always a good thing.

The SP2504C is silent, significant if you plan on stacking up more than one drive. Performance enthusiasts will benefit from two of these drives in a striped RAID array.



We haven't received too many drives based on perpendicular recording technology, so comparisons and estimates are off until market availability isn't an issue. For now, the SP2504C reigns supreme over the rest of the sub-300 GB drives available.

Runner-Up: Seagate ST3250824AS

Serial ATA (above 250 GB)

Western Digital WD4000KS

Specifications

400 GB; SATA 2 (300 MBps); 16 MB I/O buffer

Our Verdict

This drive has the show as well as the go! Purring under that matte-finished black body is a set of three platters spinning at 7200 rpm. The drive is a speedy performer, displacing even its elder brother, the WD5000KS.

The transfer rates and size of this drive make it an ideal buy for gamers, image and video editing professionals, and enthusiasts—who want speed and are not willing to sacrifice on storage capacity to get it! We've tested quite a few hard drives since August, but haven't come across anything that manages to dethrone the WD4000KS.



Runner-Up: WD5000KS

KEYBOARD / MOUSE COMBOS

Logitech MX-3200 laser

Specifications

Windows Vista ready; Internet calling buttons; 6 AA batteries; laser sensor based; soft-touch palm rest

Our Verdict

One of the first desktop combos to support Vista, the keyboard has dedicated buttons for Flip3D, a Vista feature. There is a special search button, and a touch-sensitive slider that comes in handy when using Windows Vista folders.

The keyboard sports a little LCD panel that displays the time and date as well as battery life. It also has dedicated Internet buttons for

Yahoo! and AIM messengers.

The usual set of programmable keys is present—programmable via the SetPoint software. The accompanying MX-600 mouse is laser sensor based, and offers great functionality in conjunction with the SetPoint software. Ergonomics is spot on.

Both the keyboard and mouse are made from a special material called AgION, which provides resistance to bacterial and fungal growth.

Runner-Up: Logitech MX-3000

